

Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To: Discipline Should Be Firm, Featuring Teela Jackson

Teela Jackson, Vice President, HR

Pat said, “You have to have a daily goal and you have to make a daily commitment to the goal. Once you have set that reachable goal for the day, set up a reward and penalty system. Take something away from yourself if you don’t reach the goal. In my own case, when I was training, I would set a distance I needed to run. If I should have run five miles, but only ran three, I forced myself to make it up the very next morning. I’d run two extra miles. I did the same thing with eating. If I ate too much, I’d make myself do a second workout; or if I did a great job all week with eating healthy foods, I’d give myself a milkshake. I’d go to Baskin-Robbins and get a chocolate shake made with French vanilla ice cream. That was important.”

Pat loved fostering the myth, though it wasn’t all that far from the truth, that she was ever-present and omniscient -- because although she was known as a strict disciplinarian, her hope was to never have to discipline her players. Instead, by being firm, fair, and consistent, she wanted to instill self-discipline because she knew that was the most enduring, effective, and positive form of discipline. She demanded nothing less from herself.

Coach Summitt said ...

Coach Pat Summitt

“Be firm. You need to be willing to set a precedent. It’s no good just announcing a set of rules. Trust me, whether you’re dealing with colleagues or your own child or yourself, the best way to discourage anarchy is to be uncompromising in enforcing the regulations. A stiff, non-negotiable penalty, the first time out, will prevent a repeat offense.”